Earl Carlson

Design Leader — Product Vision, Direction, and Team Building

Ann Arbor, MI (Remote) · hi@earlc.com · earlc.com

SUMMARY

Product design leader who thrives in places where the answer is not obvious yet. I've led teams across consumer products, connected hardware, platforms, trust and safety, and emerging technology.

I care about building strong teams, and designing products people actually want to use. I give senior designers room to lead, I stay close to the product, and I push for the highest bar.

EXPERIENCE

Docker — Senior Product Design Manager

2024 – 2026

Led a 12-person senior design organization (10 product designers, 8 Staff-level, and 2 design-system engineers) across a wide range of products including Docker Hub, Docker Desktop, accounts, billing, AI, and the design system, during a director-level leave. My role was to set direction, create clarity across teams, and give Staff designers and design-system engineers enough ownership to lead the work.

- Led the first major redesign of Docker Hub in more than five years, rethinking one of the company's most visible product surfaces around discovery, comprehension, and how the broader Docker ecosystem comes together.
- Led design across revenue and retention work generating $13.6M in net-new ARR, supporting 75K+ migrated subscriptions, mitigating $3.5M in enterprise churn risk, and preserving another $300K+ through churn experimentation.
- Helped define Docker's first generation of agentic products, working through new patterns for delegation, approvals, sandboxes, and how people stay in control when software starts acting on their behalf.
- Shifted more ownership to senior ICs, giving Staff designers broader product responsibility while keeping teams aligned around shared priorities and quality.
- Brought design-system engineering into the design organization and rebuilt the foundation for consistency across products. The work reduced MUI theme overrides by 76% (~2,000 lines) and introduced Storybook, Chromatic, automated accessibility checks, and a contribution model used across five product areas.
- Partnered with Product leadership on executive planning and prioritization across the portfolio.
- Led the design team's transition to AI-native product development, moving designers into Claude Code as a primary working environment while using Figma and Miro for visual exploration and collaboration.

Creative Sabbatical — Independent Practice

2022 – 2024

Took an intentional break after multiple years of continuous product leadership and development to focus on music, art, and travel before returning to lead design at Docker.

DigitalOcean — Senior Product Design Manager

2019 – 2022

Led product design across five business units as DigitalOcean evolved from a focused developer product into a broader, public company. Grew the design team from 8 to 16 designers and added a leadership layer as the organization and product portfolio expanded.

- Reworked how people, teams, projects, and infrastructure fit together in the product, helping DigitalOcean grow beyond an individual-developer tool and better support larger organizations.
- Led the redesign of account and team experiences across identity, secure sign-in, billing, roles and permissions, and account management, supporting $650M+ in ARR with 34% year-over-year growth.
- Created a framework for bringing acquired products into the broader DigitalOcean experience and brand, used across three major acquisitions.
- Established a new design system that reduced page-load time by 75%, met WCAG AA, and improved screen-reader support.
- Helped senior designers grow into broader product and leadership roles as the company expanded into new business areas.

Facebook — Lead Product Designer

2017 – 2018

Led product design focused on misinformation on a platform serving more than 1B people.

- Contributed to an 82% reduction in fake-news views through product changes aimed at improving how people encounter, understand, and share information.
- Designed fact-checking integrations with partners including Reuters, Snopes, and CNN.
- Designed an experimentation platform for news organizations to test and learn within Facebook.

DigitalOcean — Design Manager / Lead Product Designer

2015 – 2017

Helped lead DigitalOcean through a product and brand repositioning as the company expanded beyond its early developer audience.

- Managed 5 designers and 1 content strategist through the transition.
- Led design across new web properties and product experiences supporting the company's move upmarket.
- Built closer ways of working across design, community, and support as the company grew.
- Designed DigitalOcean's first alerting product.

Nokia — Senior Product Designer

2014 – 2015

Worked on an early-stage outdoor adventure camera that spanned hardware, iOS, and web.

- Led product design and vision for the web experience.
- Worked closely with industrial design and iOS teams to make the hardware and software feel like one product, from setup through capture and the supporting experience around it.

Wikia — Senior Product Designer

2013 – 2014

Designed tools for people creating and contributing across one of the web's largest community platforms.

- Redesigned the shared WYSIWYG editor used by 30M+ contributors.
- Built contributor tools supporting Wikia's broader brand expansion.
- Led design sprints across the Wikia and Wikipedia communities.

Neighborland · DFA · Skuba

2010 – 2013

Branding, advertising, and web design and development (New Orleans). Where the design career began.

EDUCATION

University of Michigan — BFA, New Media Studies

2010

Thesis examined how AI could reshape creative communities.